

RW drive—this was with the HP m7280in. A LightScribe drive can burn labels onto compatible media: you burn a CD/DVD, then flip it and burn the label! Also, the HP and HCL PCs came with wireless keyboards and mice.

The HP came with an ATi X300 SE with 128 MB of DDR RAM, which allows you to enjoy a fair amount of gaming. The Sahara R3 featured the ATi Radeon Xpress 200 graphics chip, which happens to be DirectX 9 compliant. These two MCPCs also featured TV-Out.

The Acer and HP featured multi-card readers on the front, in addition to the USB and audio connectors. The Acer needs the front USB ports since it has only two USB ports at the back, and these are used up by the mouse and keyboard.

The HP cabinet was unique: it had front connectors for S-Video and Composite In, and a removable drive bay to plug in an external hard drive. On the top was a small compartment for storing optical media.

The Acer E500 decided to do away with the stock heat sink of the Pentium 4, and came with a custom heat sink-fan assembly, in which the fan blows hot air sideways, directed towards the rear exhaust grille of the cabinet.

Being Media Center PCs, all the four came with remotes. The remote that came with the Sahara R3 was the sleekest, though it featured fewer function keys.

The HCL Beanstalk came with a decent speaker set—a 2.1 set from Altec Lansing. It came with a good software bundle, consisting of four Microsoft games and a 1,000-game CD pack.

Performance

The Sahara R3, equipped with the most powerful processor in this test (the Athlon64 3500+), scored very high in SiSoft Sandra's CPU arithmetic test. The other PCs scored better in the multimedia benchmark.

The HCL and HP PCs featured memory in dual-channel configuration, which boosted their memory bandwidth to almost double the regular bandwidth. This reflected in the memory benchmarks. Demanding applications such as video capture and gaming can benefit from this.

Armed with the ATi Radeon X300 SE, the HP scored the highest in the gaming tests, leaving the others behind by a huge margin.



HP Pavilion m7280in

The HP m7280in will therefore afford a good level of gaming.

PCMark04 again saw the HP m7280in score the best, proving that it is capable of good overall performance. In the Business Winstone 2004 benchmark, the Sahara R3 and the HP m7280in were neck and neck, posting equally good scores. These PCs are therefore not just for multimedia applications—they handle office and business applications just as well.

In the LCD display tests, the Sahara R3 scored very high in the sharpness and focus departments, but we must mention that the quality of the LCD on the Sahara R3 is not too good: it shows a colour tinge when viewed at a vertical angle, which wasn't the case with the others.

When it came to speaker quality, the Acer with its Altec Lansing speakers won hands down.

Conclusion

There were only four contenders in this category, and this was no major shootout. But these MCPCs did sport better features than the PCs in the earlier categories.

The main contributing factors towards the cost of these PCs are the operating system and components such as TV-Tuners with hardware MPEG encoders. The HP m7280in is priced at Rs 64,990, which makes it the most expensive PC in this entire test; the Acer E500 at Rs 45,999 is the lowest-priced in the MCPC category.

The HCL Beanstalk 4958 emerged the second-best, despite it not having come with a TV-Tuner card. It scored well in the gaming tests, and also exhibited higher memory bandwidth due to its dual-channel configuration.

Taking into account the three-year on-site warranty (unlike the one year provided by the others), and also the better features and performance, we awarded the Digit Best Buy Gold to the HP Pavilion m7280in.

Summing It All Up

We were disappointed at the lack of PCs targeted at gamers: most manufacturers preferred onboard graphics rather than an AGP or a PCIe graphics card, which is an absolute necessity for any decent gaming capability. The exceptions were the HP Media Center n7280in and the Acer Aspire V4324, but even these came only with entry-level graphics cards. Similarly, we felt that in the sub-25K category, the manufacturers could have easily provided CD-Writers rather than CD-ROM drives.

The Media Center market is still at a nascent stage in India, and most PC users in this country are only just waking up to the fact that such PCs exist. They haven't gotten very popular so far because of their high prices, which in turn are largely due to the fact that the XP Media Center Edition OS is tightly integrated with such PCs, and you cannot get the OS off-the-shelf—even if the components are available from abroad. This picture is sure to have changed when we test PCs the next time round; prices of MCPCs are sure to plummet. And, of course, we expect the PCs that were priced above Rs 25K to move into the sub-25K bracket. ☐

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